Smoking and Alcohol Policy

Policy Title: Smoking and Alcohol Policy

Effective Date: [Insert Date]

Review Date: [Insert Date – usually annually]

Version: 1.0

Applies to: All staff, residents, contractors, volunteers, and visitors at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]

1. Policy Statement

At [INSERT CARE HOME NAME], we are committed to promoting a safe, healthy, and respectful environment for all residents, staff, and visitors. While recognising residents' rights to make lifestyle choices, we also have a duty of care to manage risks associated with smoking and alcohol consumption.

We aim to:

- Support residents to make informed choices regarding smoking and alcohol use
- Ensure compliance with health, safety, and fire regulations
- Balance residents' independence with the safety and wellbeing of others
- Provide staff with clear guidance on how to manage smoking and alcohol use within the care home

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to:

- Set out rules and procedures for smoking and alcohol use by residents, staff, and visitors
- Reduce risks relating to fire, health, safeguarding, and behaviour management
- Ensure staff understand their responsibilities in supporting residents with safe and responsible use

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All residents, staff, visitors, and contractors at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]
- All areas of the care home building, grounds, and vehicles

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Registered Manager:

- Ensures compliance with smoke-free legislation and health & safety requirements
- Conducts risk assessments for residents who smoke or consume alcohol
- Provides staff with training on supporting residents safely

All Staff:

- Support residents to smoke or consume alcohol safely and within agreed guidelines
- Monitor for signs of excessive or harmful use
- Report concerns relating to safeguarding, capacity, or health risks

Residents and Families:

- Expected to respect the rules on smoking and alcohol use
- Work with staff to agree safe arrangements if smoking or alcohol use is part of a resident's lifestyle

5. Smoking

- Smoking is not permitted inside the care home building under UK smoke-free legislation.
- Designated outdoor smoking areas will be provided for residents and visitors.
- Residents who smoke will have an individual risk assessment covering fire safety, capacity, and health considerations.
- Staff must not provide cigarettes or tobacco to residents unless agreed within care plans.
- Residents must not smoke in bed or unsupervised in unsafe environments.
- Smoking materials must be stored safely to prevent fire risks.
- Electronic cigarettes/vapes will be risk assessed individually; their use is limited to designated areas.

6. Alcohol

- Residents may consume alcohol where it is safe, appropriate, and does not conflict with medical advice.
- Alcohol use will be discussed as part of care planning, considering health conditions, medications, and safeguarding risks.
- Staff must monitor residents for signs of intoxication, dependency, or unsafe behaviour.
- Alcohol consumption may be restricted for residents where risks outweigh benefits (e.g., safeguarding, liver disease, harmful behaviour).
- Visitors may not bring alcohol for residents without staff approval.
- Staff are not permitted to consume alcohol during working hours or be under the influence of alcohol while on duty.

7. Safeguarding Considerations

- Residents lacking capacity to make decisions about smoking or alcohol will be supported in line with the Mental Capacity Act 2005 and in their best interests.
- Any misuse of alcohol or unsafe smoking behaviour will trigger a safeguarding risk assessment.
- Residents who misuse alcohol or tobacco may be offered health advice and support to access cessation or reduction services.

8. Staff, Visitors, and Contractors

- Staff may only smoke in designated staff smoking areas, during breaks, and away from public view.
- Staff must wash hands and ensure clothing is free from smoke before providing care.
- Visitors must comply with the home's smoking and alcohol rules.
- Visitors under the influence of alcohol or drugs may be refused entry if they pose a risk.

9. Training and Awareness

- Staff will receive training on safe handling of smoking and alcohol-related risks.
- Fire safety training will include managing smoking risks.
- Staff will be trained on balancing resident rights with safeguarding responsibilities.

10. Monitoring and Review

- Smoking and alcohol use will be included in residents' regular care plan reviews.
- Risk assessments will be updated if a resident's smoking or drinking habits change.
- The policy will be reviewed annually or following incidents, new legislation, or regulatory guidance.

11. References

- Health Act 2006 (Smoke-Free Legislation)
- Fire Safety Order 2005
- Mental Capacity Act 2005
- Care Quality Commission (CQC) Fundamental Standards
- Health and Safety at Work Act 1974

12. Related Policies

- Safeguarding Adults Policy
- Fire Safety Policy
- Risk Assessment Policy
- Staff Code of Conduct
- Health and Safety Policy

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